

the women leaders who were jailed. During the satyagrah of 1940, as many as 25,000 satyagrahis arrested were from Haryana.

Financial assistance to freedom fighters

Under the Bhupinder Singh Hooda Government, a number of welfare steps have been taken to increase the financial assistance and pension to the freedom fighters and their families. The state has increased the pension of the freedom fighters and their widows from Rs 1,525 to Rs 6,000 per month. The financial assistance to the families of the freedom fighters for the marriage of their daughters has been increased from Rs 10,000 to Rs 51,000. Three per cent reservation has been provided to dependents of freedom fighters and ex-servicemen for admission to various educational and vocational courses. The freedom fighters and their dependents have been provided two per cent reservation in the housing schemes of the municipalities.

The Hooda government recently decided that a guard of honour would be given on the death of a freedom fighter. A provision of the reimbursement of medical expenses has been



Mr Bhupinder Singh Hooda pays regards to the war widows

Government honours freedom fighters

- Pension of freedom fighters and their widows increased from Rs 1,525 to Rs 6,000 per month.
- A fivefold increase in the financial assistance for marriage of daughters of freedom fighters from Rs 10,000 to Rs 51,000
- 3 per cent reservation for wards of freedom fighters and ex-servicemen in various educational and vocational courses.
- 2 per cent reservation in housing schemes of municipal bodies for freedom fighters and their dependents.
- Guard of honour given on the death of a freedom fighter.
- Free travel for freedom fighters and their wives with an assistant in Haryana Roadways buses.
- Scholarships for the grand children of freedom fighters

made for the freedom fighters. Besides, the freedom fighters and their wives along with an assistant have been allowed free travel in the state transport buses. The freedom fighters have also been given preference in the allotment of fair price shops. The incentive package for the freedom fighters and their relatives in Haryana is the best in the country, says Swatantrata Sainik Samman Samiti Chairman Puran Chand Azad.

Welfare all the way for the ex-servicemen

Similarly, the ex-servicemen have been given many benefits. The financial support of Rs 500 has now been increased to Rs 1,500 per month for the Second World War ex-servicemen and their widows. For the ex-serviceman above 60 years of age, the assistance has been increased from Rs 500 to Rs 1,000; for the paraplegic ex-servicemen, it has been increased from Rs 800 to Rs 1,000. The blind ex-servicemen of Haryana will be paid Rs 1,000 per month instead of Rs 450. The government has increased the financial assistance on the marriage of the daughters of war widows and the disabled ex-servicemen from Rs 6,000 to Rs 21,000.

The government has also increased fourfold the amount given in recognition of the the highest gallantry awards won by its soldiers. It gives Rs 25 lakh for the Paramvir Chakra and Ashok Chakra, Rs 15 lakh for the Mahavir Chakra, Rs 10 lakh for the Vir Chakra and Shaurya Chakra and Rs 5 lakh for the Sena Medal.

Over 10,000 ex-servicemen have been employed in the state government undertakings. With the construction of the district-level war memorials at Sirsa, Sonapat and Panchkula, their number has reached 18. Also, defence colonies are being set up at various places.

There has been a reservation for the disabled and free travel for the war widows in the state transport buses. The servicemen and ex-servicemen have been given reservation in group housing societies.

As a humane gesture, war widows are being given Rs 1,000 besides pension. For paraplegic ex-servicemen, the annual financial assistance has been increased from Rs 60,000 to Rs 85,000. Also, a 10 per cent rebate is given to the servicemen and ex-servicemen in the plots allotted by HUDA. ■